except for the tenure. This was again as per the rules for SSC Officers. There were no differences in the emoluments or other perquisites. The entitlements were absolutely the same. Here again, some differences were brought in. There was the concept of an all-inclusive salary, with fixed yearly increments. The first year's starting salary was kept at just Rs 20,000 per month, all-inclusive, which would have been the same as the daily wage rate for labour (who were also entitled to Dearness Allowance).[1] This was just not acceptable. Here, we were talking about a trained soldier, who was expected to lay down his life for the country. Surely a soldier could not be compared with a daily wage labourer? Based on our very strong recommendations, this was later raised to Rs 30,000 per month. Next came the issue of allowances, which was being denied. Once again, it had to be pointed out that risk and hardship allowances would have to be given. How could you have two persons on board a ship or in a bunker on the border, one getting field area allowance and the other not?[2] Sometimes, one got the feeling that these recommendations were being made with little thought to the repercussions. The same was the case with other allowances that are not part of the basic salary. How was the soldier expected to survive if he had to pay out of his own pocket for the upkeep of uniform and other such sundry expenses? Moreover, this person could be the primary wage earner for his family. Having joined the Services, he would have the added responsibility of looking after the home front; aged parents perhaps or getting a sister married. The human angle was being lost sight of.

Furthermore, the entire amount would not be paid to the Agniveers. 25 per cent of the pay would be compulsorily deducted and put in a savings fund with a matching contribution from the government. This amount, along with interest thereon, would then be given as a payout to those Agniveers released

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